Pulse – A Collection of LGBTQ Poetry

By Andrea Gibson, Sam Sax, Chen Chen, Judy Grahn, Kamilah Aisha Moon and Hieu Minh Nguyen

when the first responders

entered the Pulse nightclub

after the massacre in Orlando

they walked through the horrific scene

of bodies and called out,

if you are alive, raise your hand.

i was sleeping in a hotel

in the midwest at the time

but i imagine in that exact moment

my hand twitched in my sleep

some unconscious part of me aware

that i had a pulse

that i was alive

everyone around me spent that day grieving

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and every tear tasted like sweat drying in the morgue

later that night, i was performing for an audience

on stage,

i couldn't keep my hand from covering my heart. [1]

INTRODUCTION

In 2015, a survey called "Growing Up LGBT in America," interviewed 10,000 LGBT youth ages 13-17. The results of this survey paint a stark picture of the difficulties these youth face. According to this survey, 92% of LGBT youth report hearing negative messages about being LGBT in school or on the internet. 68% of LGBT youth report they hear negative messages about being LGBT from elected leaders. It is clear that action needs to be taken. "Pulse," a poetry program, featuring "Standards" by Sam Sax, "I Invite My Parents to a Dinner Party" by Chen Chen, "Type II" by Hieu Minh Nguyen, "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson, "A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn and "Dressing Down" by Kamilah Aisha Moon. Because silence is no longer an option.

sometimes it's a phone call from your lover

sometimes it's your computer blinking on

with news of what's wrong with your body this time

Simple really

[1] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson

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how he says the name of a disease
and suddenly you're on your back
staring out the window onto a highway [2]
in the invitation, i tell them for the seventeenth time
(the fourth in writing), that i am gay
in the invitation, i include a picture of my boyfriend
& write, you've met him two times,
but this time,
you will ask him things other than can you pass the
whatever.
you will ask him
about him.
you will enjoy dinner.
you will be
enjoyable.
please RSVP.
they RSVP. they come.
they sit at the table & ask my boyfriend
the first of the conversation starters i slip them
upon arrival: how is work going?

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i'm like the kid in Home Alone, orchestrating
every movement of a proper family, as if a pair
of scary yet deeply incompetent burglars
is watching from the outside.
i'm like the kid
in Home Alone, except the home
is my apartment, & I'm much older, & not alone,
& i'm not the one who needs
to learn
then, my mother turns
to me, whispers in Mandarin,
is *he* coming with you
for Thanksgiving?
my good friend is & she wouldn't like
this [3]
the next day i woke to the news
that an assault rifle had fired
202 bullets through a gay bar
on latin night

[2] From "Standards" by Sam Sax
[3] From "I Invite My Parents to a Dinner Party" by Chen Chen

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in one of the worst
massacres in us history -- a massacre
of people who did not leave the dance floor
when they heard gunshots
because they thought
they were just the beats
of a song [4]
my mother smiles her best
sitting with her son's boyfriend
who is a boy smile.
i smile my hurray for doing
a little better smile.
everyone eats soup.
i'm like the kid in Home Alone, pulling
on the string that makes my cardboard mother
more motherly
except she is
not cardboard, she is
my mother [5]

[4] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson
[5] From "I Invite My Parents to a Dinner Party" by Chen Chen

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They were my lovers,
but nobody had taught us how to swim.
i drowned, i took 3 or 4 others down
when I signed the confession of what we
had done
no one will ever speak to me again [6]
suddenly a woman enters the room
to wrap a black cuff around your arm
and squeeze until you're no longer sick
to slip a device under your tongue
the nowhere places you make yourself
inside the hallowed chambers of the hospital
and inside the man's unsure voice
when he calls and is too scared to name the precise
strain of letters
you might share now
what parasite might feed [7]
when you're gay in Dixie,
you're a clown of a desperate circus

[6] From "A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn
[7] From "Standards" by Sam Sax

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sometimes the only way to be like daddy
is to hate like him
hope your brothers laugh
instead of shoot [8]
every few seconds
i'd eye the balcony
for the glint
of whatever might aim
to tear the bodies
of the boys holding hands
or the girls with the haircuts short
as my temper when rage
is a decibel i can actually get to
when i'm not just frozen
and grief-sick watching history
not be history, watching
the music not be music, knowing
someone having the best night of her life
shouted, *this is my favorite song,*
And then a drumbeat lifted

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a rifle over a bathroom stall
and emptied a magazine
into the kidneys of a grown man
texting, *mommy, i'm gonna die*
his handprints in blood
on the walls, reaching
for people
dying in the fetal position,
people covered in their friend's blood,
crying too hard to hide
from their own deaths,
people outside pushing bandanas into bullet wounds. [9]
when the illness is terminal
you drink an eighth of paint thinner
while all the color drains from your face [10]
ignoring the doctor's red call [11]
funny how a word can do that
garage the body

[8] From "Dressing Down" by Kamilah Aisha Moon
[9] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson
[10] From "Standards" by Sam Sax
[11] From "Type II" by Hieu Minh Nguyen

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what if instead he'd simply called to say sorry
sometimes it's your computer blinking on with news of
what's wrong
with your body this time [12]
dressed as I am, a young man once called me
names in spanish //
then he called me queer and slugged me.
first I thought the ceiling had fallen down
but there was the counterman making a ham
sandwich, and there was I spread out on his
counter.
for god's sake I said when
i could talk, this guy is beating me up
can't you call the police or something,
can't you stop him?
he looked up from
working on his sandwich,
which was my sandwich,
I had ordered it.
"there's a pay phone

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right across the street" he said.
the next day i went to the police station
to become an outraged citizen
six big policemen stood in the hall,
all dressed as they do
they were well pleased with my story, pleased
at what had gotten beat out of me, so
i left them laughing, went home fast
and locked my door.
there is no child in me. [13]
even life is like funeral practice:
half of us already dead to our families before we die,
half of us still on our knees
trying to crawl
into the family photo. [14]
we all have our list of casualties [15]
once I loved a boy, who feared, so much
his own sickness

[12] From "Standards" by Sam Sax
[13] From "A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn
[14] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson
[15] From "A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn

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I never confessed to him my own. [16]

dear God, how broke

do you have to be

to not buy people time

to get out the door

when the song

goes to hell? [17]

death only uses violence

when there is any kind of resistance,

the rest of the time a slow

weardown will do.[18]

when this world, drunk

on hate, decides blood

is wine and drinks its fill

in the only place

they ever thought was safe?

in the only place they thought

they didn't have to hide?

in the only place they were wanted

[16] From "Type II" by Hieu Minh Nguyen
[17] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson

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because of who they loved,

and how they loved [19]

look at me! [20]

how broke

do you have to be

to not buy people time

to get out the door

until someone walked through their bodies

and asked who was still alive

and hardly anyone

put their hand up. [21]

**Cutting compliments of Rhys Jones of Mound Westonka High School, MN*

[18] From "A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn
[19] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson
[20] From "Type II" by Hieu Minh Nguyen
[21] From "Orlando" by Andrea Gibson

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SOURCE INFORMATION

"Orlando" by Andrea Gibson as found in Lord of the Butterflies. Button Poetry, 2018. ISBN 9781943735433

"Standards" by Sam Sax
https://www.poets.org/poetsorg/poem/standards

"I Invite My Parents to a Dinner Party" by Chen Chen
https://www.poets.org/poetsorg/poem/i-invite-my-parents-dinner-party

"A Woman is Talking with Death" by Judy Grahn
https://www.poets.org/poetsorg/poem/woman-talking-death

"Dressing Down" by Kamilah Aisha Moon
https://poets.org/poem/dressing-down

"Type II" by Hieu Minh Nguyen
https://www.poets.org/poetsorg/poem/type-ii

*NOTE: Poets.org is an approved NSDA website for Interpretation Events

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier (Finalist)

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